tabs on development in the constituency. "The result is an endorsement of our development agenda. Self-respect trumped BJP's money politics," says Rama Rao, citing seizures of cash by election authorities from close aides of state-level BJP leaders.

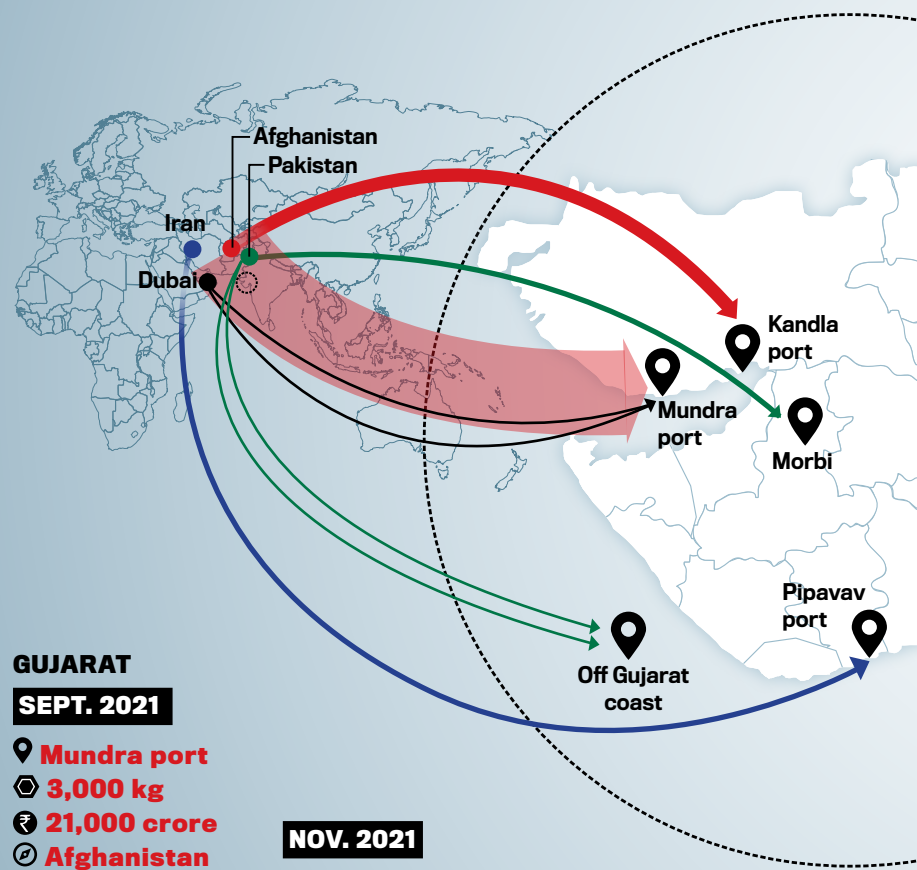
Though the Munugode victory is a shot in the arm for KCR who is toying with the idea of fielding candidates in constituencies outside Telangana with a sizeable Telugu-speaking population, analysts believe that there is still a long way before the TRS can become a vehicle for his national ambitions. KCR describes the task as a "national effort to save democracy", presumably from the BJP, with which he had friendly ties till the start of the Narendra Modi-led government's second stint at the Centre. "KCR is now painfully realising the imminent BJP threat. Due to its arrogance, his party is left with no friends except AIMIM and the Communists," says Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad. According to Vageeshan, the Munugode result should teach KCR the importance of building social alliances. "His party is trying to persuade a few politically conscious forces to come together as an anti-BJP, anti-Congress grouping, positioning itself as the 'Aam Aadmi Party of the south'," he adds.

As for the BJP, analysts say it has many challenges to overcome before it can emerge as the sole alternative to the TRS in the 2023 assembly polls. "An important strategy would be to bring in influential candidates from the TRS and the Congress," says D. Veerababu of the department of political science, University of Hyderabad, pointing out how Rajagopal's defection from the Congress added to the BJP's strength in a constituency where it never had a strong presence. The TRS, too, had used the same tactic and engineered defections of Congress MLAs after the 2014 and 2018 polls, only to find that it now faces a more formidable rival in the BJP. ■

INTERNATIONAL DRUG TRADE

HAUL OF SHAME

A year after India saw its biggest heroin haul—3,000 kgs at Gujarat's Mundra port in September 2021—the channels through which international drug racketeers sneak the contraband into India on its western coast remain active. This, even as the National Investigation Agency (NIA) has filed a chargesheet against 16 people, including six Afghan nationals and one Iranian, in the Mundra case. In Gujarat alone, the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) and the Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) have seized heroin worth over Rs 50,000 crore in the international market since the Mundra crackdown. All three major ports in the state—Mundra, Kandla and Pipavav—were landing points for the drugs originating in Afghanistan, Pakistan and West Asia. In the past two months, similar seizures have been made in Maharashtra and off the Kerala coast, with smugglers finding innovative ways to conceal the contraband, including crystal meth and cocaine sourced from South Africa, in consignments of fruits and even licorice roots. ■



GUJARAT

SEPT. 2021

- **Mundra port**
- **3,000 kg**
- **₹ 21,000 crore**
- **Afghanistan**

In the largest-ever drug seizure in India, heroin was found concealed in consignments of semi-processed talc stones. Aashi Trading Co. from Andhra Pradesh had imported the consignment from a firm based in Kandahar, Afghanistan. The drugs reached Gujarat via Iran's Bandar Abbas port

NOV. 2021

- **Morbi**
- **120 kg**
- **₹ 600 crore**
- **Pakistan**

The ATS raided an under-construction house in Gujarat's Jinjuda village and arrested three people. They had received the consignment sent by Zahid Bashir Baloch, a Pakistani national

APR. 2022

- **Kandla port**
- **260 kg**
- **₹ 1,300 crore**
- **Afghanistan**

The heroin consignment lay unclaimed at a private container freight station for a couple of days. Fake Indian firm Balaji Traders had imported the consignment from Afghanistan via Bandar Abbas port